

B2B SALES ESSENTIALS

B2B Sales Essentials — Level 1 — Day 5: Moving the Deal: Next Steps, Follow-Up, and Closing

Study guide · Self-study

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How to Use This Guide

This is your fifth and final day of Level 1, and you work through it alone. Read a section, then stop and write. The page is where the learning happens, not the reading.

You have spent four days learning how to find a client, reach them, ask good questions and map the people who decide. Today you do the part most new sellers avoid: you move the deal toward a decision, without pushing.

Two rules for today. First, answer every "What Would You Say?" exercise in writing before you look at the Model Answers at the back. Second, treat the model answers as examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you. The principle matters more than the exact sentence.

Keep a pen close. You will build your own close by the end of this guide, and it only works if you write it out yourself.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: Understand what a buying signal is, why a clear next step protects the client's decision, and why a calibrated question moves a deal further than a yes-or-no close.

Attitude: Shift from "getting the signature" to "structuring the client's thinking so their decision is their own." Accept that a well-run close can end in "not yet" and still be a success.

Skill: Close every conversation with a specific next step, including a date, and use the Commitment Close to ask for commitment without pressure.

Upskill: Run a full close from start to finish in a role-play, then apply it in one real, supervised client conversation, and write down what held you back.

Buying Signals: What the Client Is Actually Telling You

A buying signal is any moment the client starts behaving like someone already solving the problem with you. Nothing more. Before you can close, you have to hear the shift.

The shift usually shows up in one of these ways. Their language moves from the general to the specific ("our team of twelve" instead of "the team"). Their questions change from "what do you do?" to "how would that work with our current setup?" They start volunteering information you did not ask for, such as a budget cycle or an internal deadline. They bring someone else into the conversation. Sometimes they go quiet in a thoughtful way rather than a polite way.

The psychology here is simple and worth knowing. When people begin to picture themselves using something, they start filling in the details in their own mind. Those questions about setup and timing are not objections. They are a rehearsal. Your job is to notice the rehearsal and make it safe to continue.

Here is the trap. A new seller hears a buying signal and gets excited, then rushes the pitch or fires a yes-or-no question. That excitement lands as pressure, and pressure triggers the opposite of commitment: people push back on anything that feels like it is being forced on them.

A useful test: a signal is something the client does, not something you hope they feel. Write down the exact words. If you cannot quote it, it is a hope, not a signal.

What would you say? A client says, "Interesting — how does onboarding work if we start in the middle of a quarter?" Write your read of that sentence and what you would do next.

Next Steps: The Smallest Justified Commitment

A deal does not move in one leap. It moves in small, specific steps that each make sense on their own. Your first close of the day is not the contract. It is the next step.

The buyer psychology is this: people avoid large, irreversible commitments when they are uncertain, but they will take a small, reversible one. Each small step the client takes makes the next one feel more consistent with who they already are. That is not a trick. It is why you should ask for the step that genuinely fits where the client is right now, and no more.

A real next step has four parts. It is specific (what exactly happens). It has a date (when). It has a named owner (who does what, including you). And it is small enough that the client can say yes without checking with anyone first, or you have named who needs to check.

Weak next step: "I'll send some information and follow up." This asks for nothing, promises nothing, and usually produces silence.

Strong next step: "I'll send the two case examples by Thursday. Would a 20-minute call on Friday at 10 or Monday at 2 work better to walk through them with your operations lead?"

Notice the date and the genuine choice. Notice that it does not ask for the sale. It asks for a specific commitment that builds the case for the sale.

At the end of every conversation, say the next step back in one sentence and ask the client to confirm it. Confirmation is a tiny commitment, and tiny commitments keep the deal alive.

What would you say? You finish a good discovery call. The client is interested but noncommittal. Write the exact sentence you would use to lock a next step.

Following Up Without Chasing

Many deals are lost in the gaps between conversations, not in the conversations themselves. Following up is a skill, and it has a psychology.

Silence makes sellers nervous, and nervous sellers send messages that say "checking in," "following up," "just circling back." All three say the same thing to the client: I want something from you, and I have nothing new to offer. The client reads it as pressure, and pressure gets ignored.

A follow-up with value does the opposite. Each message carries something the client can use: a relevant example, an answer to a question they asked, a short summary of what you agreed. It is a gift, not a request.

Keep a simple rhythm. After every call, send a short written summary the same day: what you heard, what you agreed, what happens next and when. This protects you if the client misremembers the conversation, and it quietly shows you listen. Then follow up on the date you agreed. If there is bad

news, such as a delay or a change in what you can offer, use a call before an email. People forgive problems; they do not forgive surprises.

One more habit: never end a follow-up without proposing the next step. "Let me know if you have questions" puts the work on the client and usually ends the thread. "I'll call Thursday at 9 to talk through the two options — what would make that call useful for you?" moves it.

What would you say? A client has gone quiet for ten days after a strong second call. Write the follow-up message you would send.

Reading Readiness and the Cost of Waiting

Before you ask for a commitment, check whether the client is ready for one. Readiness is not enthusiasm. It is whether the client can explain, in their own words, why the decision makes sense.

Ask yourself four things. Do I know what the client actually wants? Do I know what is still unresolved? Do I know what evidence would resolve it? And do I know the smallest justified next commitment?

Then look at the cost of waiting, and handle it honestly. Delay is not automatically bad. Sometimes waiting is the correct decision. Your job is to make visible what genuinely changes if the decision moves: a deadline the client told you about, a cost that rises, a capacity that fills. Then let the client weigh it.

The difference between urgency and pressure is evidence. Urgency is a consequence the client can check. Pressure is making a decision feel mandatory when nothing supports it. Never invent a deadline, a shortage or a loss. The moment a client catches a manufactured deadline, you lose the deal and the relationship.

Consider the contrast.

Practice example: "Your new site opens in March and your current supplier's lead time is six weeks, per the schedule you shared. If we start by mid-January, we're inside that window." That is urgency. "You need to decide today, this pricing won't last." That is pressure, and the client will feel it.

Notice the deadline in the good version comes from the client's own information, not from you. That is the rule. Use their constraints, their dates, their numbers — and when there is no real consequence to waiting, say so. "There's no rush on our side; I'd rather you get the pilot right" builds more trust than any urgency line ever will.

What would you say? A client says, "We love it, but let's revisit next quarter." You know of no real deadline. Write your response.

The Commitment Close

Most closes new sellers learn are yes-or-no questions: "Shall we go ahead?" "Can I send the contract?" These put the client in a corner where the safest answer is "not yet." And "not yet" is almost always a request for more thinking, not a rejection.

The Commitment Close is MEDJAY's adaptation of the thinking behind Chris Voss's calibrated questions and the reasoning in Dixon and Adamson's Challenger work. It treats the close as the logical conclusion of the process, not pressure, and the client can still say no. It has 5 steps.

Criteria: restate the client's own criteria, in their words. This is not a recap of your product. It is the list of what must be true for them.

Evidence: show the evidence against those criteria. Use verified facts only — what you know, not what you assume.

Consequence: name the consequences honestly, including when waiting is better. If delay costs nothing, say that.

Calibrated question: ask a What or How question. Never a yes-or-no question. Let the client do the reasoning.

Genuine choice: offer real choices of next step, each with a date. Both options must fit their stated objective.

The psychology is why this works better than a yes-or-no close. When you ask a yes-or-no question, you are handing over the conclusion, and people resist conclusions handed to them. When you ask a What or How question, the client has to explain their own logic. That effort makes the conclusion theirs, and people rarely walk away from their own reasoning.

Practice example: "You told me three things need to be true: support within your time zone, a migration you don't have to run yourself, and a cost under five thousand per month. We can do all three — the support team sits in your region, our migration plan is the one we walked through, and the quote comes in at four thousand eight hundred. Your current contract renews in April. What would you need to see to feel confident starting before then? If it helps, we could start with your first site on the 15th, or both sites on the 1st."

Notice the closing question is a What question, and it lets the client name their own condition. If they name a condition you can meet, you have the next step. If they name one you cannot meet, you just learned something crucial and can say so honestly.

What would you say? Using the 5 steps of the Commitment Close, write a close for a client who has said yes to a pilot and needs approval from a finance lead you have not met.

Genuine Choice

Giving the client a real choice sounds small. In practice it changes everything about how a close feels.

Here is the psychology. People who feel they chose something defend that choice. People who feel they were steered into it look for reasons to back out. When you offer two real next steps, the client takes ownership of the direction. That ownership survives the hard weeks after the sale, when doubts surface.

A genuine choice sounds like this. "Would the 15th or the 22nd suit your team better for a start?" or "Would you prefer to run the pilot in one site first, or across both sites at once?" Both fit what the client told you. Both have a date or a real scope decision.

There is a line you must not cross. The two options must be real. Making both options lead to the same place ("sign today or tomorrow?") is not a choice. It is manipulation dressed up as choice, and the client will sense it, even if they cannot name it.

When They Say "Not Yet"

A "not yet" is information. Your job is to find out which kind it is, without arguing.

If the client says "not yet," three things may be happening. They may need more information ("we can't see how the migration works"). They may need someone else's agreement ("I can't decide this alone"). Or they may have a genuine constraint you did not know about ("budget is frozen until July").

Ask what part of the decision still needs to become clear. A How or What question gets you further here than "what's holding you back?", which can sound like an accusation. Then offer the next step that matches the real obstacle.

If more information: get it to them and agree when to talk. If another person: ask to include them. If a real constraint: agree a date after it lifts, and say plainly that you will wait.

This is where relationships are won. A seller who hears "July" and says "then let's agree to talk on the 10th of July, and I'll leave you alone until then" becomes the person the client trusts with the deal.

What would you say? The client says, "Honestly, I need to get my operations lead onside." Write your next sentence and the choice you offer.

Apply It in Your Role

You are new, so apply this where you already work: shadowing, supervised calls, and first real conversations with support nearby.

Before every call, write the next step you intend to ask for. Decide the date before you dial. If you do not know what step makes sense, that is a discovery problem, not a closing problem.

During the call, listen for a signal and write it down in the client's words. Do not jump to a pitch or a yes-or-no question. Ask one open question that lets the client keep going.

At the end, restate what you heard, name the next step, and ask for it with a What or How question or a genuine choice with a date. Then send a same-day summary.

After the call, log what happened: the signal you heard, the next step agreed, and the date. If your result is not one you would have predicted, write down why.

If you want to track your own numbers as you get real conversations, start recording now: calls made, conversations reached, next steps agreed, closes won — and count any close that produced a real, dated next step as a step forward, even if it was not the final sale.

What Would You Say?

Write a short answer to each before turning to the Model Answers. Keep it general. Do not use a real client's name or details.

1. A client asks a detailed question about how your service would fit their current processes. Write your read of the signal and your next question.

2. You end a solid first call. The client says, "Send me something and I'll take a look." Write your reply.

3. After a strong proposal call, the client says, "This looks good, but we're not ready to decide." Write your response.

4. The client asks for a discount to start this month. Write your answer without giving anything away for free.

5. Write the close you would actually use with a client who has met your criteria, using all 5 steps of the Commitment Close.

Key Takeaways

- A buying signal is something the client does, not something you hope they feel. Quote their words.
- The first close is the next step, not the contract. Make every next step specific, dated, owned and small.
- Follow up with value, never with "checking in." Same-day summaries and agreed dates do the heavy lifting.
- Urgency is a consequence the client can check. Pressure is a deadline only you believe in. Never invent one.
- The Commitment Close has 5 steps (Criteria, Evidence, Consequence, Calibrated question, Genuine choice) and uses a What or How question, never a yes-or-no close.
- Genuine choice gives the client ownership. Both options must be real, and both must fit their objective.
- A "not yet" is information. Ask what still needs to become clear, and never argue.

Quiz

Answer the 5 questions below before checking the key. Pick one option for each.

1. Which of the following is the strongest buying signal?

A. The client says your product looks interesting.

B. The client asks how onboarding would work with their current systems.

C. The client asks about your company's size.

D. The client says they will think about it.

2. Which next step is strongest?
   A. "I'll send some information and follow up."
   B. "Let me know if you have questions."
   C. "I'll send the two examples by Thursday. Would a 20-minute call on Friday at 10 or Monday at 2 work better?"
   D. "Shall I send the contract?"

3. A client says, "We love it, but let's revisit next quarter." You know of no real deadline. What is the most honest response?
   A. Invent a price increase to create urgency.
   B. Agree a date to talk next quarter and say plainly you see no reason to rush.
   C. Ask "Are you sure?" three times.
   D. Offer a discount to close today.

4. Which sentence is a calibrated question suitable for a close?
   A. "Shall we go ahead?"
   B. "Do you want to sign?"
   C. "What would you need to see to feel confident starting on the 15th?"
   D. "Can I send the paperwork?"

5. A client says, "I need to get my operations lead onside." What is the best next step?
   A. Ask for the contract anyway.
   B. Offer to push harder with the current contact.
   C. Ask to include the operations lead in the next conversation and offer two dates.
   D. Send a summary and wait.

Upskill Challenge

Before your next day of practice, complete three tasks.

First, build your close. Write out the 5 steps of the Commitment Close for one client you expect to speak to, in your own words. Read it aloud until it sounds like you, not like this guide.

Second, run the close in a role-play with a colleague or your supervisor. Ask them to play the client who says "not yet." Note which step felt weakest and what happened.

Third, in one real, supervised client conversation, ask for a dated next step using a What or How question or a genuine choice. Write down the exact words you used and the exact words the client used back.

At the end of the week, review what you wrote for all three tasks. Ask yourself one question: did I make the client's decision easier, or did I try to make it for them?

What's Next: Level 2. You will build on these habits with tools for larger deals. Until then, keep your discovery log, keep every next step dated, and keep your close in your own words.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Your wording should differ. What matters is the principle behind each.

1. The client is rehearsing. They are picturing your service in their own operations, which means they are partway to a decision. I would not pitch. I would ask, "What does your current setup handle well that you'd want to keep?" This lets them tell me what must be true for them, which I need for the Commitment Close.

2. "Happy to. So it's useful, can I ask what you most want to check in it? I'll put that front and center, send it by Wednesday, and call Friday at 10 to talk through it — what would make that useful for you?" This turns a vague request into a dated next step without pressure.

3. "That's fair. What would need to become clear for you to feel ready?" This is a What question that finds the real obstacle. If they name something I can solve, I solve it. If it is a genuine constraint, I agree a date and say I will wait.

4. "I understand the timing matters. I can't move the price on its own, but I can look at what we could adjust to meet you. If we found a way to start this month, what would you be able to commit to on your side?" Nothing is given away for free; a real trade is offered.

5. "You said three things need to be true: local support, a low-effort migration, and a cost under five thousand per month. We meet all three — the support team is in your region, the migration plan is the one we walked through, and the quote is four thousand eight hundred. Your current contract renews in April. What would you need to see to feel confident starting before then? If it helps, we could start with your first site on the 15th, or both sites on the 1st." The client's criteria, verified evidence, an honest consequence from their own calendar, a What question, then a genuine choice.

Reflect after reading: which model answer was furthest from what you wrote? That gap is your practice focus for this week.

- Quiz answers:
- 1. B. Asking how onboarding fits their setup shows the client is rehearsing using the service, which is a signal; general interest is not.
- 2. C. It is specific, dated, has an owner, and offers a genuine choice; the others ask for nothing or ask for a yes-or-no.
- 3. B. With no real deadline, saying so honestly builds trust; manufactured urgency is pressure and risks the deal.
- 4. C. Calibrated What or How questions let the client reason in their own words; the others are yes-or-no closes.
- 5. C. Including the missing decision-maker removes friction and offers a real, dated choice; pushing or waiting does neither.

References

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